Camino del Norte Bikepacking Expedition:

A Most Holy Spanish Pilgrimage

(and how not to bikepack)



The boys in Santiago de Compostela, journey complete. Gabe, Tim, Max, Gabriel (left to right)

Note: Our Videographer, Max produced an awesome video of this journey here:
4 Atheists Cycled 500 Miles to a Cathedral

PS: Report includes a first section directed at helping people plan their first bikepacking journey, followed by a chronological recount of the journey, with a single-page summary at the end for lazy readers.

Before the first pedal

Bikepacking is an art, as with almost any other discipline it can be taught and learnt, but the only true way is to DO, so find a route, book a train and get out there, but don't forget the **essentials:**

Bicycle (duh)



The 3 keys to a good touring bike are reliability, comfort and range (or if you're on Gabe's side; speed, pace and agility).

The most reliable frame materials are steel, aliminium next and far away in last; carbon fibre… good luck fixing a snapped carbon frame in rural Tajikistan. Tyres next, the *Schwalbe Marathons* are true masterworks of bicycle tyres, as it turned out, not one of us received a flat tyre on these for our combined 3200km ridden. There are stories of people cycling from Beijing to London on a single pair of undying, ever-reliable Schwalbe Marathons, enough said.

Comfort comes in the form of a well-padded (or well worn-in, in the case of leather) saddle, good bike shorts and, in desperate times, a reliable cycling partner who remembers to pack the magical soothing cream.

For a ride like ours, range of gears was crucial, with uphills as long as 30km and at times as steep as 25%, one front ring simply wasn't enough for Max; Tim & Gabriel's *Dawes Galaxies*, each sporting 3*9 gear ranges came out victorious.

Panniers

Panniers come in all sorts of shapes, sizes and varieties. There's plenty hype these days about front rack, handlebar, in-frame, under-frame, over-frame, next-to-frame panniers, but the simplest and most effective storage spot, as pictured above, is the rear rack. Two panniers as well as an elastic to keep loose sleeping equipment (Tent, Sleeping Bag or both). Our racks were all around the 25L range which fits all essentials with some space spare for stockups of sustenance. *Carradice* produce great, reliable panniers which are still handmade in the UK, pricey but worth the investment for gear that will last your lifetime.



Camping Gear

Now this is pretty obvious as well, get yourself a good sleeping bag, if you're on an exped, borrow a tent from the board, who kindly lent us their *MSR Hubba Bubba 2-man* which was ultra light and super spacious, a roll mat and some of us even brought camping pillows (to Tim's chagrin…). A stove and gas canister can't be forgotten either, just don't bring the gas to the airport unless you want to end up on a no-fly list.

All The Rest

With the above you can get yourself nearly anywhere in the world with enough time and effort, but it's always worth bringing the following as well, in order of importance: Wallet + Passport, Pocket Knife, Head Torch, Battery Pack, Shades, Water Bottles, Bike Tools + Pump, Toiletries, First Aid Kit, Bike Lock (if travelling solo).

Clothing

Now some more boring admin:

- 2 pairs of pants - no more, no less
- A few pairs of socks
- Long Sleeve + Short Sleeve Riding Shirts
- Waterproof Jacket
- Bike Shorts
- Swimmers + Tiny Towel
- Beanie +/ Snood - even in summer, an alpine camp can get chilly overnight
- 1 set of casual clothes, it doesn't hurt to look (or smell) normal once in a while
- Spare shoes for camp (optional, barefoot works)



(not so) Essentials

Us bikepackers love to pack our lovely little things, expecting to find free time during the tour to play, read or otherwise use our trinkets - though this is often in vain as the true life of an authentic bikepacker is that of constant activity:
riding, refueling (food, water, beer), setting up camp, refueling, resting, refueling, packing up camp and riding again



Regardless, the following are essential for a smooth ride:

- Cool Lycra Shirt, the tighter the better
- Instrument
- Book(s), just pack one you probably won't even start it
- Pack of Cards
- Football, size 2 max.

The key is to keep these pieces compact but also useful



Gabe lamenting the photographer for sending him up a gravel road

Route Planning

As chief route planner, I spend the majority of my, albeit infrequent, time in lectures scouring bikepacking.com or simply scrolling google maps for beautiful landscapes I see as suitable for a bike tour. The Camino del Norte is a historic hiking path and Spain is renowned for being a road cycling Mecca so combining the two was a natural course of action for a group of avid bikepackers limited on time with work responsibilities and exams respectively. A start and end point are always good places to start, in this case Santiago de Compostela was the obvious finish line, the site of the Cathedral, and for the start point - Santander as the only port with a ferry arriving from the UK on a good date.



With that set out, the next step is finding where you'll be sleeping each night. In practice, we found that we only slept in 1 of the 9 spots we had designated in our planning. Aim for ~80km plus or minus depending on whether your path is flat or hilly / rough - down the flat highway 101 I averaged 110, in the Rockies just 60. When you are out there, anything can happen, you could have a slow day, or a fast day, you may have to divert if the route isn't how it seemed, you may find somewhere better to sleep en route etc. Regardless, this is a crucial step in route planning, not just for your exped application, but so that you can gather a general idea of daily distances, locations of refuel spots, and you have a fallback every night for a place to end up and avoid the worst case scenario - having to pay for a place to sleep.

Tricks of the Trade

***Streetview* is your best friend:** kind people of the world love taking 360 photos, and keen route planners love viewing them, these get you a real, in-person view of the path you'll be on, indicating road surface, use it whenever you can.

***Maps.ME* is your partner:** possibly the greatest application one can have on their phone. This allows you to download highly detailed and navigable maps, with footpaths as well as roads and even some wild campsites, all for free.

***Warmshowers* is the secret lover**: for a £25 lifetime membership you can message kind hosts (who are also bikepackers) in advance en route for a warm place to stay, this can be a godsend after days/weeks without a shower.

Search terms on maps only get your so far: there comes a point with things like wild camping spots and refuges just require a proper scan on satellite view, sometimes it's as complicated as seeing a building outline in the mountains and searching the coordinates on google *or asking locals*, other times it can be as easy as an accommodation pinpoint.

Nothing goes as planned: as you'll see we felt this full throttle, encountering rough surfaces on steep inclines, it's important not to expect too much so as not to be disappointed. On the flip side, this can work in your favour too, for example, our best campsite (picture below) was found completely by accident on our way to the spot we'd planned for.



Companionship

So here you are, sitting on your laptop in your bedroom alone, late at night, with the most incredible bike tour planned. You could go solo, and I've had plenty of fun in my own experience doing so, but nothing beats getting out there with a group of mates and battling through the tough uphills together, sharing the joys of the freewheel downhill and regaling each other with stories by a campfire.

One of the most amazing things about the Imperial Exploration Board grant (and other related grants) is that it makes these activities accessible for others who haven't done them before. We were all avid cyclists but Gabe and Max were both without suitable bikes, nor panniers and camping gear to accompany them which made the grant ever more helpful.

So, pick a group of mates who are up for it and it doesn't hurt to have a practice trip before the big thing. A month or so before we departed, Tim, Gabe and I spent a weekend riding from Sheffield to Birmingham through a touch of the peaks, the rolling yorkshire dales and finally the flat canals of Brum. These climbs proved to be nothing in comparison to what we'd experience on the Camino but it was a valuable team building experience and the power of companionship came forth early when my chain wedged into the cogset and we needed Tim to stabilise the bike while Gabe, the mechanic, levered the stubborn, wedged links out with expert precision.



Careful your expedition mates don't get along too well...

Report Writing

As stated above, the Imperial exploration board is an invaluable resource for getting your bikepacking journey going. Writing a proper report requires meticulous planning, and expect grilling at the meeting. In my experience, I'm not the greatest at writing these so it helped to apply for the November meeting and receive feedback before February. Here's the table of contents from our proposal as a loose guide:

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if you have any queries.



It pays to be prepared... packing bikes on last day in Porto



On The Road

Prologue: Surviving a 30 hour ferry

In order to get to Spain we decided on taking the boat. By far the easiest travelling experience with a bike. Literally a roll-on, roll-off experience. Our ferry journey began in Portsmouth and would deliver us in Santander two and a half days later....

Long distance ferries (happy sigh), one of life's most blesséd experiences. As we biked past the long queue of cars waiting to board our hearts soared. With a 10 pack of Cruzcampo (to get into the Spanish spirit) strapped to our bikes we felt well prepared for the next few days on a boat. Travelling off season on a ferry is a unique experience; we were certainly the youngest on board and maybe the only individuals under 50. A pack of cards in hand, joyful grins on our faces, we sat in for the long ride. This time was spent with a mixture of long distance lorry drivers, the retired and the mixture of pet dogs that these two groups had brought. Highlights included watching the half time dog show and talking about our best kisses we had ever had.

30 hours seemed to fly by and in no time we were docking and looking forward to our first Spanish cafe con leche y tortilla after only consuming beer and sugar for the last few days. In Santander we would meet Gabriel, who, looking as greasy as ever (and maybe more so?!), and greeted us with a few tales of his own travel experiences.



Prologue 2: (Simultaneously) A Foray Into Urban Camping - Gabriel

They say 'home is where you lay your hat'. As I settled into the muggy firewood store on the outskirts of Bilbao I must say it didn't feel quite like home, for there was no home cooked meal, crackling fireplace nor front door. I had been forced to eschew the ferry due to my exam the morning after it set off, so I took a flight to Bilbao to catch the others. Making it to the city around 7pm, there was still plenty of light to pick up last minute supplies and meet some locals. The basque culture is one of firm independence and the people were very welcoming in spite of my only speaking Castillian Spanish.

Once dark, I headed to a spot of green on the map to find a pleasantly empty park, though it was a bit light and since the other lads had the tents, I had to find a shelter of my own. Naively I exposed my position in the dark by using my flashlight to locate the abandoned hut but regardless I got in. The complementary pair of night scares involved a flashlight scanning my area and two distant fluorescent pairs of wild eyes, thankfully not wide enough apart to be boar. I got a suitable few hours of sleep and packed my bike a second time for my 7am bus to Santander where I met the boys.

Day 1: Windy and Windy (Santander to Pimiango -80km)

After reconvening and enjoying coffee in Santander, we set off west. Today was about gaining some distance and breaking in our gear, ready for the peaks to come. Komoot sent us off the main roads with some lovely windy farm roads connecting to unpaved trails. Once out of the urban sprawl we experienced the rolling hills that Spain is full of, there was hardly a meter of flat riding as we strenuously surged up steep hills before feeling the fun of a fabulous freewheel down.

Around midday we had our first proper break, colonising a playground with our traditional combination of milk and bread. Turning north, we joined up to the official Camino del Norte bike route for a flat stretch, exiting the busy road and taking a gravel riverside path to our second spot for some sangria.



Morale was high as we rolled passed tomorrow's turning point south, indicating we had only a few miles left to our campsite, but the uphill to follow took the last bits of energy out of everyone's sore legs as we climbed up a measly, but steep and rough 150m from Unquera to Pimiango. Setting up camp around sunset, we had an ocean view and despite Gabriel's claim of hearing a Scottish farmer shout 'Get off me land', we survived the night.

Day 2: Uphill Battle (Pimiango to Pido - 65km, 3000m elevation)

Setting off from Pimiango, we had a morning of calm before the metaphorical storm, that being a hefty 1600m net climb. We stuffed ourselves with breakfast at the petrol station before a picturesque canyonside ride towards the Rio Cares. The cliffs above, and eventually below us, were immense, and the vast mountain landscapes with distant snow-covered peaks forewarned of what was to come.



Teamwork came in incredibly handy as we cruised 40km in around 2 hours to Las Arenas where we stuffed our gobs and stocked our bulging panniers with pantries worth of food. Tortillas, Empañadas, Apples, Sweets, Biscuits, Gabe's favourite: Piña Colada and, of course, plenty of Milk - let's hope the bothy has an outhouse!

Cheery boys on the A264 towards Sotres, anxiously anticipating a 1500m ascent. Tim, Gabe and Max (Left to Right)

We were granted the joy of a pleasantly shallow incline to start along the Cares, before we turned on to a monstrous 830m climb to Sotres, the end of the road. Halfway along, Gabe naïvely described the climb as "Probably the hardest climb I've done in my life". Despite this, Tim and Gabe led the pack with Max and Gabriel trailing slowly, a good 10 minutes behind. The road carving the south side of the Rio Duje was absolutely incredible. The valley was cavernous and arches cut through protruding heads of rock acted as mile markers to keep us motivated. It was a complete slog, but eventually we reached Sotres around 2pm at 1050m altitude, just over halfway there!

To cap off our road slog, we celebrated with a brief descent into a subalpine valley housing an old abandoned village and a gaggle of wild horses and cows. Within 2 minutes we were back on the up, lugging our stallions up a steep slithery gravel trail which looked just to go on and on. And go on and on it did. It was a biblical push, flipping between measly short stints of riding and trudging through unrideable terrain, yoyoing with hikers up to a clearing where we spotted a lone hut by the side of the path. We stopped there for some much needed whiskey and a distance check. 2 hours after topping out the road in Sotres and we were only 75% of the way up to our peak, tough news to take but it was pleasant for our tired, aching bodies to know we were close. 20 minutes on, we had convinced ourselves the topout shortly ahead of us was a false summit but as we rounded over we spotted a lovely site, a serene and stoic standing stone, stood strong as though it were guarding the mountains behind in Gadolfian fashion. At last we had done it. We stopped at a church before taking on the downhill for a pint in Espiñama as we sought to find a refuge. No sign of any nearby on Google Maps, nor MAPS.ME, but one unlikely source, a rogue Google result on mapcarta had a set of coordinates labelled "Refugio Pido" which we trusted for the night. Turning up it was clearly some old, unused Shepherd's outbuilding but it served us well as we crashed early after a heavy day's work.



This magnificent standing stone marked our summit, our path courteously skirting left of the snowy westward peaks

Day 3: The Second Reckoning (Pido to Riaño - 50km, 2000m elevation)

After a comfy sleep in a disused shepherds hut, we cruised down a gorgeous windy, paved road to Cosgaya for breakfast in a layby. From here we set off on a juicy incline, the path never as rough as the afternoon prior, but in many points far steeper, we estimated a few steep sections around 25 degree incline. It was a hell of a slog, we aimed to rest and stuff our faces every 100m or so of incline, in the end it was more like every switchback, intersected by a short rapid stint of granny gear grinding or for others, donkey mode, trudging up the hill with our heavily laden bikes.



Morning mist obscuring the path ahead



The road heading west from our summit

Once we passed the treeline, the gradient smoothed out and we were able to ride more consistently up the gravel, that was until we were apprehended by thick snow patches controlling a good chunk of the pass' north face. It had been around 4 hours now that we'd been climbing but in spite of this our achy legs were overjoyed to feel ice cold snow on this scorching day. The view south of yesterday's path was incredible, a cavernous valley separating us from level ridges and peaks 1000m higher than our measly 1678m altitude. Once around the pass, the view opened up to an endless, magnificent series of mountains in every direction, steep and fierce limestone peaks shot out from lush green fields. I thought I could see Alex and Sophia clambering up a distant sheer face but it was another pair of mountain goats.

Now came the moment we'd been dreaming of for hours as we trudged up our thick gravelly path: The Descent. I'm generally a freewheeler in moments like these, slowly cruising, catching my breath and appreciating the panoramic view that engulfs me, Gabe and Max not so much; these star-studded speedsters held their self-described 'Super Tucks', maintaining a posture as aerodynamic as a salmon up a stream winding with twists and turns, navigating ascendant ridgetops, into cavernous valleys and through vast open plains before reaching a small end-of-the-road town for beer, they assured me they hadn't already had one when Tim & I caught up around 15 minutes later and we all sat down for a ration of Morcilla (black pudding soup), before deciding our ravenous hunger demanded a second portion; the waitress carefully analysing the situation, supplied us with a secondary surplus. Onwards, we basked in gorgeous sun down to the strange town of Riaño, our best guess is they tried to rebuild the town at the base of the reservoir after it flooded,resulting in a mismatch uncanny old-fashioned feel to the newish village, nevertheless the butchers was open much to our delight.



At camp, we reaped the rewards of our hard work, chowing down on campfire hot rock chorizo, a trick Benedict had taught Tim and I last year on our kayaking course in Devon, in preparation for the expedition that never was. It's a delicious treat and perfectly satiates the fat cravings that long days on the bike give you - just beware of hot rocks exploding! The sun dipped behind the peaks on the other side of the reservoir but it remained light, a pinky-purple haze falling upon us. Eventually our only source of light was the dwindling campfire that I graciously put out before bed.

Day 4: Off-Roading (Riaño to Vergecervera - 70km)

We woke up in a campsite that stunk of piss, god only knows….

So we got swiftly moving along a flat section of paved road, slightly busier than we'd have liked but fortunately directly west. We reached a nice quaint mountain village for our first rest before a turn that nobody expected, we were back on gravel baby! It's fair to say Gabe wasn't happy one bit but alas we pushed on to the peak 350m above.



The descent was heavenly, just the right level of steepness that my weak brakes could handle while allowing for some speedy freewheeling on bumpy terrain. We spent most of the time eyes down looking how to swerve to avoid the rocks. The village road was perfect solace after the morning's busy road as we sped along to the Polma Reservoir. Spain has an extensive network of reservoirs for all of its rivers, and hence thousands of sunken villages with only old church spires poking out to evidence their existence. With variable ages came variable pace, so after some tough days we started to spread out more and had to remind each other to properly stick together (sorry Tim that was a low blow).

While there did exist a more direct route, a unanimous decision was made to stick to the road for the rest of the day, so we cut along for 20km until around 7pm when we had to find a campsite, a field just south of a campsite was ideal for a free night and we had a great evening playing Boules with our apples alongside sipping Sangria.

Day 5: A Birthday Well Spent (Vergecervera to Villablino - 110km)

We arose in our wonderful campsite, the sun just peeking from beyond the eastward peaks that engulfed us in our valley base. Gabe was 22! To celebrate, we had the same breakfast as always, and got on our bikes quickly. We restlessly anticipated the party at the bothy tonight. We were pelotoning down the open road, as hours passed like minutes. It being Spain, the flat terrain had to end eventually, and we turned north towards another reservoir, this one a few hundred meters above us. I'll run out of synonyms soon, but the landscape was once again sublime, incredibly vast ranges stretched in every direction, a teal blue sky above accompanied by crystal blue water below. Sharp, fin-like peaks leapt out their flooded valley bases with gorgeous, psychedelic limestone formations.





We stopped for a rest in what looked like part of a bridge that never was, abandoned but perfect shade for us, and a challenging boulder problem for Gabe. Having spent a little too long static, and realising a wrong turn earlier had extended our day by 20km; we got on the move. We hugged the reservoir's edge to a natural turn off and the world around us expanded into fiercer mountains, some snowcapped. The flat, windy road was a comfortable ride but the saddle directly ahead of us indicated an incline was due, so we climbed and climbed up to our mountain pass where we encountered a whole new kind of terrain. The yellow grass reminded me a lot of the borders of BC and Washington near Midway, and the terrain too; like someone was designing this world and started with a perfectly flat base, dropping mountains around to their hearts content and missing a few spots.

After our 60km slog from the last proper stop, we reached the ski town of Villablino and rested for some well-deserved Cervezas. Additionally we stocked up for the night before our grand journey up to our first proper refugio. Refugio de la Escrita is located 1500m above sea level so we had quite a hike from Villablino's modest 1000m. We started the hike in the light, climbing a bit up the shepherd's path that wasn't quite suitable for our bikes, before stashing them aside and hiking the remaining 2 miles. We summited in the dark and stumbled into our refugio, with a wonderful 3-stack bunk bed and campfire, for a heavy, heavy night.




Y quien se ha ido
Extrañaremos al viejo
que pedía un euro en el mercado
que no supimos su nombre
Y siempre estuvo a tu lado.
Y quizás el viejo pobre
era tu Dios disfrazado
Nunca preguntaste el nombre
porque estabas apurado.
Y todo será un milagro
Y todo será un legado
Y se respelará la vida
la vida que hemos ganado.
Cuando la tormenta pase
rápido Dios, apenado,
que nos devuelvas mejores,
como nos habías soñado.
En homenaje a todas las personas
que de alguna manera han sufrido
el covid-19.
BMC
ANFF
Asturiana
Il fumo danneggia i tuoi polmoni

Day 6: The Morning After (Villablino to Trabadelo 85km)

After all waking up fresh as a bunch of daisies and struggling to understand the aftermath of the birthday celebrations, including cleaning a very sticky trangier…, we headed down to collect our bikes and head off for a day of biking. This day was a tough nut of a cycle tour day - and remember there are always a couple. Tim seemed to be ailing increasingly with several bad knees and ankles (all ligaments were in extreme pain and the sympathy from the rest of the gang was tangible). Pain medication came in the form of frequent very required cigarette breaks which got the morale back up. Believe it was Tim's first ever back-to-back cigarette (sorry Mum).

Anyways, I digress, the biking was beautiful and included a stop for a coffee (a beer for Gabriel?) and some Tuna pasties that quickly became a fan favourite on the trip. We ended the day with our first night in an Albergue (a pilgrim hostel) which included dinner. The host asked whether we wanted aqua or vino with the food. A quick head nod settled that and we quickly warmed up to some nice local bottles of red….

Day 7: Are We There Yet? (Trabadelo to Palas de Rei 110km)

After the beauty of the last few days there was now a desperate desire to get to our end destination. After our first night in a bed (and our first shower) we were all feeling a little fresher and decided to get on with a big day. Writing about this day after the trip is strange… What happened? What did we do? What did we talk about?

There was some seriously good rapping by the Gabe duet which sped us on. And in all honesty there were some very beautiful views and some sweet down hills. Lunch included raiding a local supermarket and eating a horrendous amount of soggy omelet in a crisp sandwich which got a few photos from the locals and our bellies feeling as wobbly as the omelets were moments before….

After our first taste of an albergue we were desperate to find another - it never occurred to us that we would be chasing comfort so soon again. And we landed on the most corporate of them you could find which was in a very beautiful village none the less. Shared with a high school of spanish teenagers, we showered, Tim the medic popped the most pus filled infected spider bite on Max arms - truly disgusting experience - and we tucked in to rest.

Day 8: The Pilgrim's Progress (Palas de Rei to Santiago de Compostela 55km)

Battered, ugly, greasy and full of an unimaginable quantity of beige food we got back on the bike for our final days riding. Head down, we focused on getting some quick kilometers down on some busy roads. After a nice slow lunch which included some wine (of course - it being the final day), we found a picturesque route that would take us to the cathedral. With many "buen caminos" said and waves shared with fellow pilgrims we wiggled our way through (somehow losing Tim in the process) to the centre, arriving in the main square in full sunshine.

Despite the process of this bike ride not feeling particularly holy, this moment did lead to some spiritual reflection (at least for some in the group). Gabriel, being as itchy footed as he is, allowed us 5 minutes of this blissful reflection before telling us that he was bored and we needed to do something. What a GUY.

After several hours of umming and ahhing we found a place to stay for the night, washed parts of our body that were in dire need of it and got comfortable in the thought of not having to get back on our bikes. We started, relatively sociably and respectably with a few cervezas in the sun….

Day 8 part 2: The Art of the City Break

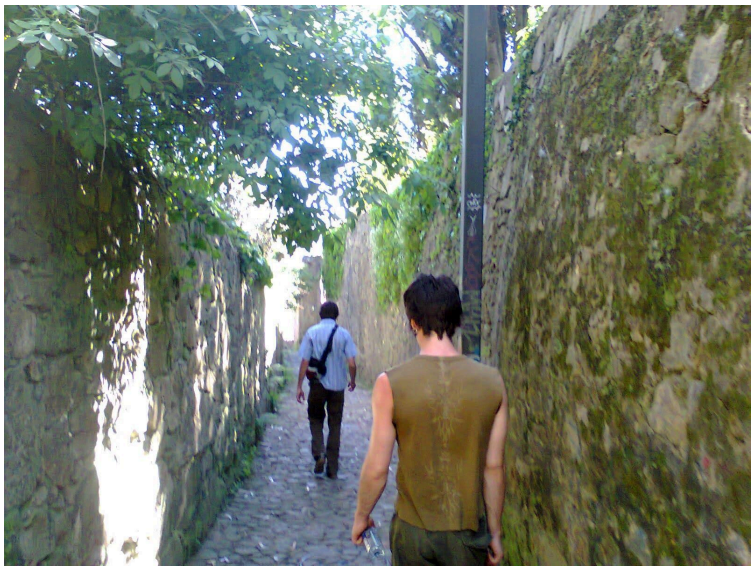
A few cervezas past and the celebratory boxed wine came out to play, which ended up taking out one of our soldiers who shan't be named. Well, Tim went back along with him as the sun dipped following another decent day's ride to close off the pilgrimage and Gabriel and Max continued on with the night.

Once the Monks and Nuns settled in for their early nights, the scoundrels of town came out and the streets were bustling, every nook and cranny housed a cozy bar between grandiose medieval façades. Gabriel practiced his Spanish but unfortunately his lack of Galician meant the duo weren't provided with the location of tonight's forest rave. As the boys continued hopping bar to bar, having chats (which involved Max doing a lot of Spanish earwigging), they received a recommendation for a club on the other side of town. It had a nice quiet feel, mostly dark with a few red lights (not those kinds, Tim...) and heavy techno music blasting and keeping the boys up until 6, when they got back to the airbnb, Tim and Gabe were just about packing up for our excursion south to Portugal!





So the boys crashed for an hour or two until it was time to check out and get moving to Vigo, here we left Tim behind as our cultural export to improve our image as Brits in this town (especially after last night)... onwards the trip continued through Villagarcia d'Arousa, Vigo and onto Porto - not much is remembered from these final days except the hectic final morning, which started at 2pm mind you, hustling to find equipment to pack up bikes and get on the plane home.





The Camino was a route of twists and turns and highs and lows; but mostly highs as we cruised above 1000m altitude for over half of our 750km ride. Three of the group boarded a ferry from Portsmouth to Santander in preparation and met Gabriel by the dock. The first day was blistering, as we navigated backroads and trails hugging 85km of the serene Basque coast.

We rose early to the sight of fog clearing as the sun rose from the direction of our target camp, a remote bothy, which was 1400m above our coastal camp, just past the horizon's towering snowy peaks. Swift progress was made as we formed a peloton through 40km of flat highway at the base of a canyon before our slow incline began. The rest of the day was a great trudge up remote gravel paths, at times having to walk our pannier-laden stallions when the going got tough. We peaked around 1500m before a hairy descent to some cold beers in Espinama and a short ride to our unoccupied shepherd's hut up the road.

The next morning started similarly to the last, with a brief cruise down 600m of the altitude we had gained the evening before, all before 4 hours of pure sweat and tears (and minimal blood) as we rose to our highest point of the trip at 1678m, at points walking through patches of snow which obscured the path. The sights were incredible all the way up which made up for the tough effort and we relished the smooth tarmacked downhill for an easy-going 30km down to Riano. We made camp by the reservoir's edge and a brave few swam to cool off.

One thing we hadn't noticed in our trip planning was the lack of flat roads all along the north coast of Spain, even having passed our major ascents now, the ups and downs along quiet country lanes connecting expansive reservoirs were constant. The next day was only 60km, but with another strenuous gravel climb and our legs terribly sore from the previous day's effort, we didn't make it to camp until sunset at 8.

Day 5 was Gabe's birthday, and we celebrated suitably, with an 110km ride followed by an hour's hike up to a refugio (bothy) right upon a snowy peak. The wooden bunks felt like prime luxury for our sore bodies and there was even a fireplace which we made good use of, up late partying in our wonderful home for the night.

It was a steep trek the next morning down the old shepherd's path, gathering our bikes stashed by the path we followed on south. This whole journey we had yet to spot a cloud in the sky, which continued this morning as we descended 500 metres into scorching heat. As we came down from our ridge up above, we descended to the official Camino de Frances and passed many a pilgrim on their own spiritual journeys, hoping to reach Santiago for Easter Sunday the following week. That evening we got our best taste yet of pilgrim culture, staying in an albergue (pilgrim's hostel) for just 12 euros each. Following much needed showers, we enjoyed a warm, healthy meal served with local red wine and an early bed preparing for our penultimate day on the road to Camino de Santiago

The newly found comfort of a bed and warm shower had entranced us, so we set off for the town of Outeiro 110km west. We passed through quiet villages and quaint towns swarming with religious imagery including the grand monastery in Samos and the majestic medieval village of Portomarin. At this point we had gotten into a good routine as a team and made great pace over to our albergue with minimal breaks.

The final morning was quite momentous, we had now cycled a total of 700km as a group, through countless valleys and over many impressive peaks and as the road signs changed from Castilian to Galician we knew we were approaching our final destination. We rode past swathes of sweaty hikers into Santiago feeling knackered but accomplished after the past week of non-stop riding, the palatial cathedral and surrounding old town marking a fine endpoint to explore on foot for a change.

For me, this trip was very transformative. Having taken Spanish lessons at my university for the last three years in anticipation of a year abroad next year, it was a great confidence boost to have proper conversations with native speakers about a range of topics; be it culture, sports or just ordering beers. We all grew much closer as a group during this period and overcame setbacks of injury and struggles of exhaustion by coming together as a team.